



GHANA

Capital city: Accra**Area:** 92,455 sq miles
(239,460 sq km)**Population:** 20,900,000**Official language:**
English**Major religions:** Christian
69%, Muslim 16%,
traditional beliefs 9%,
other 6%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Cedi**Adult literacy rate:** 74%**Life expectancy:** 55 years**People per doctor:** 10,000**Televisions:** 99 per 1,000
people

GHANA

GHANA SHOULD BE A RELATIVELY wealthy country. Its many riches include fertile farmland, reserves of gold, bauxite, and oil, and a young population that is among the best educated in Africa. However, years of unstable government, low earnings from exports, and bad management of the economy have hindered Ghana's development. More than 50 different ethnic groups live in Ghana, each with its own language and traditions. Among the largest groups are the Akan peoples, who include the Ashanti in the south of the country, the Dagomba in the north, and the Ewe in the southeast.



THE AKOSOMBO DAM

One of the world's largest artificial lakes, Lake Volta, is formed by the Akosombo Dam on the Volta River. When the dam was built in the 1960s, about 85,000 people had to be moved from areas flooded by the lake. The dam's power plant generates electricity for factories in the city of Tema and for domestic use. Some power is exported to Togo and Benin.



SLAVERY

Between 1500 and 1800 over 10 million Africans were sold into slavery. Many were shipped from Ghana to work on plantations in the Americas and the Caribbean. Elmina Castle (above) was built by the Portuguese to hold slaves before they crossed the Atlantic. Once on board the slaves were kept in terrible conditions and many died before they reached land.



Ashanti gold head showing
a defeated enemy general.

THE ASHANTI

When Europeans first visited Ghana in the 15th century, they named it the Gold Coast because of the gold offered to them in trade by the local people. The main gold workers were the Ashanti. The symbol of Ashanti unity was a golden stool, which they believed had come down from the sky. Gold from the Ashanti mines is still an important export for Ghana.



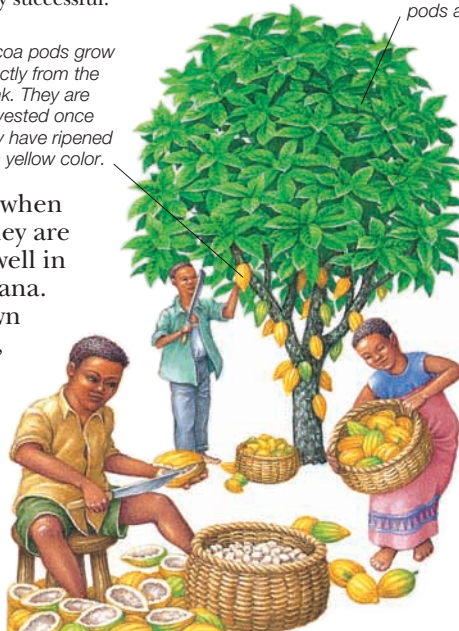
Women traders at the market in Accra

MARKETS

Every Ghanaian town has a bustling market, drawing people in from the surrounding area. Here they can buy and sell a wide range of goods, from food and animals to household supplies and even false teeth. Many of the market traders are women, often involved because "marketing" is part-time and leaves the rest of the day free for other work. Many traders are financially very successful.

A mature
cocoa tree
produces
20–30 fruit
pods a year.

Cocoa pods grow
directly from the
trunk. They are
harvested once
they have ripened
to a yellow color.



COCOA

Cocoa trees need plenty of shade when they are young and water when they are mature. This is why they grow so well in the humid forests of southern Ghana. Here young cocoa plants are grown between rows of other food crops, which provide the necessary shade. The trees only begin to produce fruit after about seven years. Cocoa production is a major industry, accounting for up to 34 percent of the country's exports, but Ghana now faces stiff competition from neighboring Ivory Coast and from Southeast Asia.



Cocoa beans are
fermented, roasted,
and ground to produce
a chocolate liquid. This
is used to make cocoa
butter for cosmetics,
or is reheated and
molded to make blocks
of chocolate.

Find out more

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